

POWERING DISCONTENT People protesting against the installation of smart electricity meters in Jammu, Aug. 26

AP

JAMMU & KASHMIR

A DIFFERENT POWER STRUGGLE

from the Jammu region—with the highest-ever vote share of 23 per cent. The annulment of Article 370 and creation of the two Union Territories of J&K and Ladakh in August 2019 was overwhelmingly welcomed in the Jammu region, further widening its rift with Muslim-majority Kashmir.

But with the reorganisation ushering in reforms in almost all sectors, including power, the region is now seeing unease. "The prepaid smart meters are not acceptable to us," says JCCI president Arun Gupta. "People are getting inflated bills because most meters are running fast and showing excessive readings." The trade body, unsatisfied by the verbal assurances given by the authorities during a meeting on August 8, has sought them "in writing" and could intensify the protests after the festive season.

Electricity is the most talked about issue in J&K, particularly in winters when the demand for power increases to run heaters, geysers, radiators and crude boilers amid sub-zero temperatures in many parts. Till the early '90s, the government used to supply firewood to households ahead of winters, but the practice has since been abandoned, leading to a spike in power demand. There are other factors, too, that have contributed to this persistent power crisis: unabated

THE INSTALLATION OF SMART POWER METERS RAISES TEMPERS IN BJP STRONGHOLDS OF JAMMU REGION

pilferage, transmission and distribution losses (57 per cent, highest in the country), and a mounting revenue deficit amid a rising power purchase from outside (16.2 billion units in FY22, up from 13.3 billion in FY20). In Kashmir valley alone, peak power demand surges to 2,400 megawatt (MW) in winters, double the 1,200 MW in summers. But the supply could touch just 1,850 MW last year, leading to long power cuts due to transformers getting damaged by overloading or discom-enforced load-shedding. But Javed Yousuf Dar, chief engineer, Kashmir Power Development Corporation, is hopeful the situation will improve once 100 per cent smart meter installation is achieved by 2025.

It was the then Mufti Mohammad Sayeed-led People's Democratic Party (PDP) government that had made the first attempt to regularise power supply in J&K with the installation of electricity meters in 2005. But a majority of about 2.2 million connections remain unmetered, and the consumers continue to pay nominal charges. In Jammu, for instance, against an expenditure of Rs 3,600 crore last fiscal, the power utility could generate just Rs 2,100 crore revenue, a whopping 42 per cent deficit. To curb these losses, the J&K administration in 2022 told power utilities in both provinces to roll out smart metering—a part of the nationwide Revamped Distribution Sector Scheme to improve the quality and reliability of power supply.

Smart meters allow consumers to check their daily power usage and charges, allowing them to plan consumption as per their needs and resources. The prepaid system, meanwhile, improves revenue collection as payment is done before consumption, avoiding arrears and defaults. The system, explains Dar, brings in transparency by doing away with manual meter readers, thus curbing pilferage. In the first phase, 600,000 meters are to be installed in J&K—250,000 in Jammu and 350,000 in urban pock-